B1 Grammar

# Articles: a, an, the or no article

When to use a, an, the or no article at all, with the slip Arabic speakers make most.

English has two articles: *a/an* (indefinite) and *the* (definite). Many nouns also take no article at all. The choice depends on whether the listener knows which thing you mean.

| Article | Use | Example |
|---|---|---|
| a / an | One thing, mentioned for the first time | *I saw a dog in the park.* |
| a / an | Jobs and descriptions | *She's an engineer. It's a good idea.* |
| the | Something already mentioned, or clear from the situation | *The dog was huge. Can you close the door?* |
| the | Only one exists; superlatives; ordinal numbers | *the sun, the best day, the first time* |
| no article | Plural and uncountable nouns used in general | *Dogs are loyal. Water is essential.* |

**A or an?** Choose by sound, not spelling: *a university* (you-), *a one-way ticket* (wun-), *an hour* (silent h), *an MBA* (em-).

**Common mistake.** Arabic uses *al-* for general ideas, so learners write *The life is hard* or *I like the coffee*. In English, general ideas take no article: *Life is hard. I like coffee.*

## Practice

1. I bought ___ new laptop last week. ___ laptop is very fast.
2. She wants to be ___ architect.
3. ___ honesty is important in ___ friendship.
4. This is ___ best film I've ever seen.

5. We stayed in ___ hotel near ___ Nile.

6. Correct the mistake: The children need the love and the attention.

# Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

## Answers

1. a, The
2. an
3. no article, no article (Honesty is important in friendship.)
4. the
5. a, the (rivers take *the*)
6. Children need love and attention.